THE 12 WEEK YEAR

Get More Done in 12 Weeks
Than Others Do in 12 Months

Brian P. Moran & Michael Lennington

AUDIOBOOK FOLLOW-ALONG OUTLINE
& ACTIONABLE GUIDE

THE EXECUTION SYSTEM

The 12 Week Year is an execution system built on a paradigm shift: stop thinking in calendar years and start treating every 12 weeks as its own year. Compress your time horizon, focus on a few critical goals, and execute weekly. The system rests on a foundation of three mindset principles, applied through five operational disciplines. The annual plan is a barrier to high performance because it lulls you into believing there is plenty of time. There isn't.

THREE PRINCIPLES (the mindset)

ACCOUNTABILITY	COMMITMENT	GREATNESS IN THE MOMENT
Ownership, not consequences	**A personal promise, not interest**	**Choice precedes results**
You always have choice. Accountability is the willingness to own your actions and results regardless of circumstances.	A conscious decision to act to create a desired result. When committed, you accept no excuses, only results.	You become great the moment you choose to do what greatness requires. Results are simply confirmation of greatness already chosen.

FIVE DISCIPLINES (the mechanics)

1. VISION	2. PLANNING	3. PROCESS CONTROL	4. MEASUREMENT	5. TIME USE
Compelling future bigger than present. Personal vision fuels business plan.	12-week plan with focused goals and action-level tactics you can execute.	Weekly plan + WAM (Weekly Accountability Meeting) install your habits.	Lead and lag indicators. Score your execution weekly (target 85%).	Strategic, buffer, and breakout blocks. A model week that protects focus.

Core Insight: Annualized thinking kills execution. December feels far away in January, so urgency dissolves and bad weeks pile up unnoticed. By treating every 12 weeks as a complete year, you get 12 fresh starts a year, no time to coast, and a deadline always near enough to keep you focused. You have only 12 weeks. Every week counts. Every day counts.

BOOK STRUCTURE

Section	Reference	Theme
PART 1 — THINGS YOU THINK YOU KNOW		
Ch. 1: The Challenge	Ch. 1	Execution is the single greatest market differentiator
Ch. 2: Redefining the Year	Ch. 2	Periodization; 12 weeks = 1 year; discard annualized thinking
Ch. 3: The Emotional Connection	Ch. 3	Vision creates the why; personal vision fuels business goals
Ch. 4: Throw Out the Annual Plan	Ch. 4	12-week planning is more predictable, focused, and structured
Ch. 5: One Week at a Time	Ch. 5	The Weekly Plan translates 12-week plan into daily action
Ch. 6: Confronting the Truth	Ch. 6	Measurement drives execution; 85% rule on weekly scorecard
Ch. 7: Intentionality	Ch. 7	Performance Time: strategic, buffer, and breakout blocks
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Ch. 13: Establish Your Vision	Ch. 13	Aspirational, 3-year, and 12-week visions
Ch. 14: Develop Your 12 Week Plan	Ch. 14	Goal-setting and tactic-writing criteria for execution
Ch. 15: Installing Process Control	Ch. 15	Weekly Plan, WAM, and the Weekly Routine (3 steps)
Ch. 16: Keeping Score	Ch. 16	Lead/lag indicators; weekly scorecard at 85%
Ch. 17: Take Back Control of Your Day	Ch. 17	Performance Time blocks and the Model Week
Ch. 18: Taking Ownership	Ch. 18	Reject victim thinking; four actions for greater accountability
Ch. 19: 12 Week Commitments	Ch. 19	Personal commitments and promises to others; the iceberg
Ch. 20: Your First 12 Weeks	Ch. 20	The launch playbook in three 4-week phases
Ch. 21: Final Thoughts & the 13th Week	Ch. 21	Reflect, regroup, reload for the next 12 weeks

PART 1

THINGS YOU THINK YOU KNOW

The paradigm shift: why annualized thinking sabotages execution and how the 12-week year creates urgency, focus, and breakthroughs.

CHAPTER 1

The Challenge

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 1

> *"Knowledge is only powerful if you use it, if you act on it. Great ideas are worthless unless they are implemented." — Brian P. Moran*

CORE LESSON

The number one thing holding people back is not lack of knowledge, intellect, talent, or connections. It's lack of consistent execution. Most people already know what to do; they just don't do it. Execution is the single greatest market differentiator, and the gap between what people know and what they actually implement is where most performance is lost.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The 2,000-Agent Insurance Company: A perennial top producer was repeatedly asked by other agents to share his approach. He'd take time out of his busy schedule to walk them through exactly what he did. Number who replicated his success: zero. He eventually stopped sharing because no one followed through. The lesson: the secret isn't secret — the gap is in execution.

The $60 Billion Diet Industry: 65% of Americans are overweight. 46,000 diet books exist. Most people know that healthy eating and exercise produces fitness. They just don't do it consistently. It's not a knowledge problem — it's an execution problem.

Ann Laughman — MassMutual Houston: A successful financial advisor who felt she was capable of more. She didn't change her market, her clients, or her case sizes. She simply executed the same critical activities more consistently. Result: a 400% production increase and the first female Associate of the Year in MassMutual Houston's 103-year history.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Execution — not strategy, talent, knowledge, or connections — is the single greatest differentiator between mediocre and great performers.
2. Most people have the capacity to double or triple their results just by consistently applying what they already know.
3. The gap between knowing and doing is where performance dies. Closing that gap is the entire purpose of the 12 Week Year.
4. It's not what you know, it's not even who you know — it's what you implement that counts.
5. If you've fallen short of what you're capable of in any area of life, look critically. The breakdown is almost always in execution, not in strategy or knowledge.

CHAPTER 2

Redefining the Year

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 2

"It's what you learn after you know it all that counts." — John Wooden

CORE LESSON

Annualized thinking is the silent killer of high performance. With a 12-month horizon, December feels far away in January and urgency dissolves. The fix: redefine your year as 12 weeks. Periodization — a focused training technique used by Olympic athletes — applied to business. Each 12 weeks stands alone. The deadline is always close enough to create urgency, yet far enough to get real work done.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The December Phenomenon: In most industries, the last 5–6 weeks of the year produce 30–40% of annual sales. Activity spikes, distractions fall away, and people focus on what matters. Why? Because of one arbitrary date — December 31st — that triggers urgency. The 12 Week Year creates that same end-of-year energy four times every calendar year.

Eastern European Olympic Training (1970s): The original application of periodization. Athletes focused intensely on a single skill for 4–6 weeks, then moved to the next. The result: maximum capacity in each skill. Moran and Lennington adapted this principle for business.

The Billion-Dollar Brokerage: Doubled its sales productivity in six months by moving off the annual cycle. The authors note this is impossible operating on annual execution — the time horizon itself caps the result.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Annual goals are often a barrier to high performance. They lull you into believing there's plenty of time, so urgency disappears and bad weeks pile up unnoticed.
2. The end-of-year push works because of a deadline, not because of December. Recreate that energy every 12 weeks and you transform your output.
3. 12 weeks is long enough to get real work done, short enough to maintain urgency. There's no time to put off critical work; every week counts.
4. Every 12 weeks is a fresh start. A bad year doesn't drag on for 9 more months. A great year doesn't tempt you to coast. You reset, reload, and re-engage.
5. Stop thinking in calendar years. The 12-week year is your year. The next 12 weeks should feel like your entire annual game compressed into one focused stretch.

CHAPTER 3

The Emotional Connection

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 3

"Behind every impossible achievement is a dreamer of impossible dreams." — Robert K. Greenleaf

CORE LESSON

Execution requires uncomfortable action. Without a compelling reason, people choose comfort every time. The way through is a vision so emotionally compelling that you want it more than you want short-term comfort. Personal vision fuels business vision — not the reverse. Your business is the means; your life vision is the end.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The Amygdala vs. the Prefrontal Cortex: When you imagine a future radically bigger than your present, the amygdala (the brain's risk-avoidance center) tries to shut the process down. The PFC, however, lights up when you contemplate compelling futures and open vistas. By regularly thinking about an inspiring vision, you literally rewire your brain through neuroplasticity — strengthening the part of you that pursues greatness.

The 'Crisis of Vision': When passion is missing in business or relationships, people call it a crisis of passion. It's not. It's a crisis of vision. Find a compelling vision and passion follows automatically.

The Mental Rehearsal Effect: Research shows that the same neurons fire when you vividly imagine acting on your vision as when you actually act. You can train your brain to execute by repeatedly engaging with a clear, emotionally compelling future.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. The number one thing you must sacrifice to be great is your comfort. Without a compelling vision, you'll choose comfort every time.
2. Personal vision must precede business vision. Your business is just one part of your life, and it gets its meaning from the life it's meant to enable.
3. Vision is the starting point of all high performance. You create everything twice: first mentally, then physically.
4. If you lack passion in any area, you actually lack vision. Fix the vision and the passion returns.
5. Your brain physically changes based on what you think about. Spend time with your vision daily and you literally strengthen your capacity to act on it.

CHAPTER 4

Throw Out the Annual Plan

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 4

"If you don't know where you are going, you'll end up someplace else." — Yogi Berra

CORE LESSON

Annual plans fail because they are objective-based, not action-based. You can't reliably predict what to do 11 months from now, so annual plans default to vague targets and bloated goal lists. 12-week plans are different: more predictable (shorter horizon), more focused (1–3 goals max), and more structured (tactics that are specific, actionable, dated, and assigned). Plans aren't for show. They exist to drive execution.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The Three Benefits of Planning: Planning reduces mistakes (you make them on paper, not in execution); saves time (counterintuitive but proven); and provides focus when day-to-day noise tries to pull you off course.

The Cross-Country Trip Analogy: Most people spend more time planning a vacation than planning their business. Imagine driving from Miami to Chicago with directions that say 'drive in the general direction of Chicago.' That's what most business plans look like.

Be Great at Few vs. Mediocre at Many: Most annual plans contain too many objectives — a primary reason execution fails. The 12-week year forces focus on the top 1–3 goals that will have the greatest impact.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Annual plans are objective-based and rarely executable. 12-week plans are action-based and specify exactly what to do each week.
2. Predictability decreases with time. You can plan reliably for 12 weeks; you can't plan reliably for 12 months.
3. Less is more. Fewer goals = better focus = better execution. Be great at a few things, not mediocre at many.
4. Tactics must be specific, measurable, action-oriented, time-bound, and have an owner. Vague tactics produce no execution.
5. If you're not working from a written plan, you're trusting your memory and willpower. Both fail under pressure.

CHAPTER 5

One Week at a Time

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 5

"An ounce of action is worth a ton of theory." — Ralph Waldo Emerson

CORE LESSON

While we plan for the future, we act in the day. Long-term results are created by daily and weekly actions, not by quarterly or monthly intentions. The Weekly Plan translates your 12-week plan into focused weekly action. It's not a to-do list — it's a 1/12 slice of your 12-week plan, containing only the strategic activity due that week.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Sir William Osler — Day-Tight Compartments: The founder of Johns Hopkins School of Medicine credited his success to living life in 'day-tight compartments.' Plan for the future, but act in the day. The future is built one moment at a time.

The Predictive Power of Daily Action: Want to predict your future health? Look at your current eating and exercise habits. Want to predict your marriage? Look at how you interact with your spouse. Want to predict your income? Look at your daily work activities. Your current actions are creating your future.

The 12 Week Year Compression: A year becomes 12 weeks. A month becomes a week. A week becomes a day. When you compress time this way, every day's value increases dramatically and you can no longer afford to coast.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. The Weekly Plan is your most important execution tool. Spend 15–20 minutes at the start of each week reviewing the past week and planning the next.
2. Spend the first 5 minutes of each day reviewing your weekly plan to set that day's actions.
3. The Weekly Plan is not a glorified to-do list. It is the strategic activity from your 12-week plan that must happen this week.
4. Carry your weekly plan with you. Check in with it multiple times a day. If a tactic is due, don't go home until it's done.
5. Your daily actions are the most accurate predictor of your future. If you want to know where you're heading, watch what you actually do today.

CHAPTER 6

Confronting the Truth

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 6

"In God we trust. All others must bring data." — W. Edwards Deming

CORE LESSON

Measurement is the anchor of reality. Without it, you can't know if you're effective. Most people track lag indicators (results) but ignore lead indicators (the activities producing the results). The single most powerful lead indicator is your weekly execution score — the percentage of planned tactics you actually completed. Hit 85% consistently and you'll hit your goals.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Why Sports Are Motivating: Sports captivate players, coaches, and fans because we keep score. At any moment, every participant knows exactly where they stand. Business mostly fails to keep score, and so people drift through quarters with no clear feedback.

Frederick Herzberg's Research (1960s): The top two motivators in the workplace are achievement and recognition — and you can't have either without measurement. Contrary to belief, scoring builds self-esteem because it documents progress.

The 60% Rule: When results don't come, more than 60% of the time the breakdown is in execution, not in the plan. But people instinctively change the plan first. This is a mistake. If you're not working the plan, you don't know whether the plan works.

Productive Tension: The uncomfortable feeling you get when you're not doing what you know you need to do. Most people respond by quitting the system to turn off the light. High performers use that tension as fuel to act.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Measurement isn't accountability — it's feedback. Use it to learn, not to punish.
2. Track both lead and lag indicators. Lag = results (income, weight). Lead = actions (calls made, workouts completed). Lead indicators predict; lag indicators report.
3. The 85% rule: complete 85% of your weekly tactics and you'll hit your 12-week goals. Strive for excellence, not perfection.
4. Execution score is more important than the result for the first 12 weeks. Master the process; the results follow.
5. Don't change the plan if you haven't been executing it. First confirm where the breakdown is — plan content or plan execution. They require different fixes.

CHAPTER 7

Intentionality

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 7

> *"It's not enough to be busy, so are the ants. The question is, what are we busy about?" — Henry David Thoreau*

CORE LESSON

Time is the great equalizer and the great revealer. Everyone has the same amount; what separates great performers is intentionality. The fix isn't to eliminate interruptions — that's impossible — but to block out specific, protected time for high-value work. Performance Time uses three block types: strategic blocks (3 hours of uninterrupted work on what matters), buffer blocks (handle email and admin in batches), and breakout blocks (3-hour breaks to recharge).

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The 2-Hour Daily Loss: A salary.com study found the average person wastes nearly two hours of every working day. Multiply by working days and the cost is staggering.

The Strategic Block: Three hours, no phones, no email, no visitors. Just one focused session per week. Most people are astonished by the quantity and quality of work produced. It's the highest-leverage time block in the system.

The Breakout Block Paradox: Many entrepreneurs work longer and harder, killing their creative edge. Sometimes the most productive thing you can do is take time off during normal business hours. A three-hour breakout block, scheduled deliberately, returns you to work with focus and energy you couldn't have produced any other way.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. If you're not in control of your time, you're not in control of your results. Period.
2. Strategic blocks: 3 hours, once per week, of uninterrupted high-value work. Schedule them early in the week so they can be rescheduled if disrupted.
3. Buffer blocks: 30–60 minutes, 1–2 times daily, to batch-process email, voicemail, and administrivia. They contain the chaos instead of letting it run your day.
4. Breakout blocks: 3 hours away from work, scheduled during business hours. They prevent burnout and protect your creative edge.
5. Build a Model Week on paper. If your important activities can't fit on paper, they won't fit in real life. The exercise forces hard choices about what stays and what goes.

CHAPTER 8

Accountability as Ownership

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 8

> *"Our last free act, after which no further free acts are possible, is to deny that we are free." — Peter Koestenbaum*

CORE LESSON

Accountability is the most misunderstood concept in business. People treat it as consequences imposed on others when behavior fails. That's not accountability — that's punishment. True accountability is ownership: the willingness to own your actions and results regardless of circumstances. It cannot be imposed. It can only be chosen. And the foundation of accountability is the recognition that you always have a choice.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The 'Have-To' Trap: When something feels like a 'have to,' it's a burden, and you'll deliver minimum standards. When you reframe it as a 'choose to,' you tap your full resources and bring your best. The fact is: there are no have-tos in life. Even with requirements, you still choose how to engage.

The Misuse of 'Hold People Accountable': Managers and leaders constantly say, 'we need to hold people more accountable.' Moran argues that's literally impossible. You can hold a baby or a bag of groceries, but not someone's accountability. What managers actually want is consequences for behavior. Confusing the two creates victim cultures and pushback.

The Empowerment Inversion: When you stop waiting for the economy, the company, the boss, or the spouse to change — and own that the only things you control are your thinking and your actions — you move from resistance to empowerment, from limits to possibilities, from mediocrity to greatness.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Accountability is ownership, not consequences. It's a character trait, a stance in life.
2. You always have choice. Even in a constrained environment, how you engage is yours.
3. The only accountability that truly exists is self-accountability. No one else can hold you accountable — only you can.
4. Stop waiting for outside circumstances to change. The only things you control are your thinking and your actions. But those are enough.
5. Accountability actively confronts the truth. It's not passive. It requires courage to look honestly at your situation and own it.

CHAPTER 9

Interest vs. Commitment

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 9

> *"Commitment is an act, not a word." — Jean-Paul Sartre*

CORE LESSON

There's a profound difference between being interested in something and being committed to it. When you're interested, you do it when circumstances permit. When you're committed, you accept no excuses, only results. The four keys to successful commitment: (1) strong desire, (2) keystone actions, (3) count the costs, and (4) act on commitments, not feelings.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Brian Moran's $500 Bet with His Father: After a freshman year on academic probation, Moran made a commitment to his father to get all A's the following semester — with money on the line either way. He pulled out all the stops, made the grades, and never went back to the wrong dean's list. The $500 was forgotten quickly. The commitment changed his life.

Mick White's Phone Calls to His Mom: At a 12 Week Year workshop, Mick committed to calling his mother every weekday. Sometimes it felt like a burden. He kept it for 88 weeks and 440+ calls. On a Friday in June 2011, he had his last conversation with her. She died unexpectedly that Monday. He has priceless voicemails, deeper memories, and no regrets.

The Four Keys in Action: (1) Strong desire makes obstacles look like challenges, not barriers. (2) Keystone actions — the 1–2 core activities that drive most of the result. (3) Counting the costs lets you commit consciously, not naively. (4) Acting on commitment, not feelings, is what builds momentum on the days you don't want to.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Interest is conditional. Commitment is unconditional. Know which one you have before you promise something.
2. Find the keystone actions — usually 1–2 core activities — that account for most of the results. Focus there.
3. Count the costs honestly before committing. Time, money, comfort, missed opportunities. Decide if the prize is worth the price.
4. Act on your commitments, not your feelings. Feelings are unreliable; commitments built into structure are not.
5. 12-week commitments are easier than annual ones. You can keep a promise for 12 weeks. At the end, you reassess and recommit. Repeat.

CHAPTER 10

Greatness in the Moment

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 10

"The best thing about the future is that it comes one day at a time." — Abraham Lincoln

CORE LESSON

Greatness is not achieved when results show up. Greatness is achieved much earlier — in the moment you choose to do what greatness requires. Results are simply confirmation of greatness already chosen. This means you can be great today, regardless of past performance, simply by choosing to do the things you know you need to do.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

Michael Phelps: Phelps didn't become great when he won his 18th gold medal. He didn't become great when he won his first. He became great years earlier when he chose to put in the extra hours in the pool, eat the foods his body needed instead of the ones he wanted, and build mental resolve. The medals were evidence of greatness already chosen.

The Multitasking Trap: Modern life rewards constant connection — in meetings while checking email, on calls while texting. The result: nothing gets full attention. Not the important projects, not the important conversations, not the important people. We end up mediocre by default.

The Slim Margin: The difference between greatness and mediocrity is small. For a salesperson: 2–3 extra appointments a week, 5–10 more calls a day, 3 hours of strategic work. For a leader: recognizing one more person, delegating one more task, giving praise to a struggling teammate. Tiny moves, accumulated daily — enormous outcomes downstream.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Greatness is chosen, not earned. The choice happens before the result, not after.
2. You are most effective when you are mentally present where you are physically. Athletes call it being in the zone.
3. The future is created in the now. Right now is all you have to work with. The next 12 weeks will reflect today's choices.
4. Multitasking is the enemy of greatness. Full attention to one thing produces excellence; split attention produces mediocrity at everything.
5. You can be great starting today. The past doesn't matter. The choice to do what greatness requires is available in this moment.

CHAPTER 11

Intentional Imbalance

Section Reference: Part 1, Ch. 11

> *"There's no such thing as work-life balance. There are work-life choices, and you make them, and they have consequences." — Jack Welch*

CORE LESSON

Life balance is a misnomer. Trying to spend equal time across every life domain is impossible and counterproductive. Real balance is intentional imbalance — being purposeful about which areas get your focus during which seasons. The 12 Week Year is a tool for applying deliberate focus to a few life areas at a time and making real progress.

KEY STORIES & EXAMPLES

The Seven Areas of Life: Spiritual, spouse/partner, family, community, physical, personal, and business. Score each one 1–10 by your own definition of satisfaction. The areas that drain you spread their effect across all the others. The areas that energize you do the same.

Goal vs. Keystone Approach: For each life area, you have two options. Build a full 12-week plan with multiple tactics, or commit to a single keystone action and execute it for 12 weeks. Sometimes one workout per day is more powerful than an elaborate fitness plan.

The Compound Effect of 12-Week Cycles: You can't finish a master's degree in 12 weeks, but you can make significant progress. Breaking large goals into 12-week segments creates consistent progress and milestones to celebrate — which keeps motivation alive.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Life balance is intentional imbalance, not equal time. Different seasons call for different focus.
2. Score yourself on the seven life areas. The lowest scores reveal where 12-week focused effort will produce the biggest jumps.
3. You can apply the 12 Week Year to any life area: relationships, health, finances, spirituality, creative pursuits. Same system, different domain.
4. Sometimes a single keystone action is more powerful than a full plan. One date night a week. One workout a day. One call to a parent. Compound it over 12 weeks and the change is profound.
5. Career energy and personal energy are connected. A draining career leaks into family. A fulfilling career fuels everything else.

PART 2

PUTTING IT ALL TOGETHER

The application: 3 principles, 5 disciplines, and the specific tools to install the system in your life and business.

CHAPTER 12

The Execution System

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 12

"A year from now you'll wish you had started today." — Brian P. Moran

CORE LESSON

The 12 Week Year is a closed system: it contains everything needed to succeed. It's organized as 3 principles (the mindset) and 5 disciplines (the mechanics). Implementing some pieces produces some benefit. Implementing all of them produces breakthrough — because they amplify one another. The system also helps you navigate the Emotional Cycle of Change, the predictable five-stage emotional ride that accompanies any meaningful change.

THE EMOTIONAL CYCLE OF CHANGE (ECOC)

1. Uninformed Optimism: The exciting beginning. All upside, no downside visible yet. You brainstorm and strategize.

2. Informed Pessimism: Reality enters. The costs become clear. You start looking for reasons to abandon the effort.

3. Valley of Despair: The most dangerous stage. Pain is felt, benefits feel far away. Most people quit here. This is where a compelling vision matters most.

4. Informed Optimism: You're still committed. New behaviors are starting to feel routine. Benefits are starting to appear.

5. Success and Fulfillment: The new behavior is the new normal. Costs are gone. Confidence is built. You're ready for the next change.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. The 12 Week Year is a closed system. The whole is exponentially greater than the parts. Apply it fully or you'll get partial benefit at best.
2. The 3 principles are mindset: Accountability, Commitment, and Greatness in the Moment. Without them, the disciplines won't stick.
3. The 5 disciplines are mechanics: Vision, Planning, Process Control, Measurement, Time Use. Without them, the principles produce no execution.
4. The ECOC is predictable. Knowing it's coming means you won't quit when you hit the Valley of Despair. You'll recognize it as a stage, not a verdict.
5. The 12 Week Year is your operating system. Other business processes are software. The OS stays the same; the software can change without chaos.

CHAPTER 13

Establish Your Vision

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 13

Vision moves through three stages of thinking: **impossible** → **possible** → **probable** → **given**. The first shift comes from asking 'what if?' instead of 'how?' — 'how' too early shuts down the imagination. Once a vision is possible, planning begins. Once execution starts, it becomes given.

THREE TIME HORIZONS FOR VISION

(1) Aspirational vision — 5, 10, 15 years out. Bold, inspiring, encompassing all life areas. **(2) Three-year vision** — concrete picture of professional and personal life in 36 months. **(3) 12-week goals** — what you'll achieve in the next 12 weeks that moves you toward the longer horizons.

SAL DURSO’S FIREWEED STORY

> Sal lost a major part of his firm's revenue when key advisors left and took clients with them. On a trip to Alaska, he saw fields of fireweed — purple flowers that are the first sign a forest is regenerating after a fire. He returned home, met with each team member to ask what made the firm special, and crafted a new vision. A year later he wrote: 'The fireweed has emerged. Our firm is a better place because of what happened a short year ago.' Vision turned loss into rebirth.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Don't ask 'how?' too early — it shuts down imagination. Ask 'what if?' first. Move to 'how?' once the vision is alive.
2. Personal vision precedes professional vision. The professional vision exists to fuel the personal one.
3. Big visions outperform small ones. Small visions don't call on your best.
4. Share your vision. Telling someone increases your commitment.
5. Stay in touch with your vision daily. Print it. Review it. Update it. It's not a document — it's a living tool.

CHAPTER 14

Develop Your 12 Week Plan

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 14

Plans solve the problem of how to close the gap between today and your 12-week goal. They reduce uncertainty, eliminate guesswork, and force trade-offs you'd otherwise avoid. The plan should be focused on 1–3 goals, no more. Each goal gets its own set of tactics that meet five criteria: specific and measurable, stated positively, a realistic stretch, accountability assigned, and time-bound.

PATRICK MORAN'S STARTUP CAPITAL RAISE

Patrick had been raising capital for a healthcare startup for six months with no result. He applied the 12 Week Year. Battle cry: 'every day is a week.' First week: finished a 100-page Private Placement Memorandum. Second week: legal review, green-lit. Reached out to hundreds of personal contacts. Closed the first round on October 10th. Investors and team members remarked on the company's cadence. The 12 Week Year turned a stalled effort into rapid execution.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Start with a well-written goal. Specific. Measurable. A realistic stretch. If the goal is vague, the plan will be too.
2. Tactics must start with a verb, be a complete sentence, and be executable as written in the week they're due.
3. Less is more. Fewer goals, fewer tactics, sharper focus. If you can hit the goal with four tactics, you don't need five.
4. Don't aim for a perfect plan. Aim for a good one and refine through execution. Patton: 'A good plan today is better than a perfect plan tomorrow.'
5. Plans build capacity AND drive short-term results. Always include activity in the current 12 weeks that produces revenue or visible progress.

CHAPTER 15

Installing Process Control

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 15

Mike Tyson said everyone has a plan until they get hit in the mouth. Process control is the set of tools and events that keep you working your plan even when you get hit in the mouth. Two core tools: the **Weekly Plan** (a 1/12 slice of your 12-week plan, populated automatically by what's due that week) and the **WAM** (Weekly Accountability Meeting), a 15–30 minute peer meeting that increases follow-through dramatically.

THE 'CHANGE OR DIE' STUDY

A Fast Company article documented patients with severe medical conditions requiring lifestyle changes to survive. After 12 months, 90% had reverted to old habits — even facing death. The exception: patients in peer support sessions had a nearly 80% success rate. The lesson: willpower alone fails. Peer support multiplies success seven-fold. Don't go it alone.

THE WEEKLY ROUTINE (3 STEPS)

(1) Score your week — calculate what percentage of last week's tactics you completed. **(2) Plan your week** — pull this week's tactics from the 12-week plan onto your weekly plan. **(3) Participate in a WAM** — share results, score, intentions, and get feedback from a small peer group. 15–30 minutes, weekly, non-negotiable.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. The Weekly Plan is the most powerful execution tool you have. It is not a to-do list. It is the strategic activity due this week from your 12-week plan.
2. Don't go it alone. Peer support increases your success rate up to 7x. Find 2–4 committed peers and meet weekly.
3. The WAM is not punitive. It's not about holding others accountable. It's about fostering ownership through shared confrontation of reality.
4. The Weekly Routine takes 15–20 minutes total: score last week, plan this week, attend the WAM. That's it. Skip it and the system collapses.
5. Productive tension is healthy. The discomfort of seeing where you're not executing is exactly what compels action. Don't turn off the light — use the tension.

CHAPTER 16

Keeping Score

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 16

Measurement is the touchstone with reality. Effective measurement combines lead indicators (activities) with lag indicators (results). Most people only measure lag, missing the chance to course-correct early. The single most powerful lead indicator is your weekly execution score: the percentage of planned tactics you completed.

ADAM BLACK'S 65% RESULT INCREASE

Adam Black, a hard-charging Type A, started the 12 Week Year and built a simple paper calendar with two daily metrics tied to his 12-week goal. Every night he knew exactly where he stood. The result: 65% increase in unit and dollar volume in one year. He qualified for a top-producer trip he'd never reached before. His takeaway: measurement doesn't have to be complicated, but it has to be timely.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Measure both lead (activities) and lag (results) indicators. Lag tells you how you did. Lead tells you how you'll do.
2. Score your weekly execution. 85% is the target. Hit it consistently and the goals follow. Below 60% is a red flag requiring intervention.
3. Don't change the plan if you haven't been working it. First confirm the breakdown is in execution or in the plan content. They demand different fixes.
4. More frequent measurement = more useful measurement. Weekly beats monthly. Daily beats weekly when feasible.
5. Don't abandon the system after a bad week. Most people quit when scores are low. That's exactly when staying engaged matters most.

CHAPTER 17

Take Back Control of Your Day

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 17

It's not lack of time that limits you — it's how you allocate the time you have. Performance Time uses three block types: **strategic blocks** (3 hours, uninterrupted, for high-payoff work), **buffer blocks** (30–60 minutes, batched email/admin), and **breakout blocks** (3 hours away from work to recharge). Build a Model Week with these blocks scheduled, then live it.

ANNETTE BATISTA — OUTREACH COUNSELOR OF THE YEAR

Annette had a demanding job: 650 phone calls and 100 home visits per month, plus presentations and community contacts across six zip codes — while raising a family and homeschooling her son. She used buffer blocks for email (7:30–8:30 AM), strategic-style blocks for calls and visits (8:30 AM–12:30 PM), a breakout block for homeschooling in the afternoon, and a closing buffer block. She finished call lists 1–2 weeks early and won Outreach Counselor of the Year in 2011 and 2012 — the first person to win it twice.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Performance Time is not about eliminating interruptions — it's about protecting blocks of time for high-value work.
2. Strategic block: 3 hours, uninterrupted, once a week, scheduled early so it can be rescheduled if disrupted.
3. Buffer block: 30–60 minutes, 1–2 times daily, to handle email and admin in batches instead of letting them control your day.
4. Breakout block: 3 hours away from work, scheduled. Without it, your creative edge dies and burnout creeps in.
5. Build a Model Week on paper. If you can't fit your priorities on paper, you can't fit them in real life.

CHAPTER 18

Taking Ownership

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 18

Victim mindset is the enemy of execution. Blaming the economy, the company, the boss, the spouse, or the politicians keeps you helpless. Accountability — ownership of your thinking and actions — is the only path to results. You don't control circumstances. You control your response. That's enough, if you're willing to own it.

DUSTIN CARTER — THE WRESTLER WITH NO LIMBS

As a young boy, Dustin had a rare blood disease that required amputation of both arms and both legs. If anyone ever had a reason to feel sorry for himself, it was Dustin. He chose wrestling. Through hard work and hours of training, he became an accomplished wrestler and an inspiration to millions. The author writes: 'When I think about what Dustin had to overcome and the things I let hold me back, I'm embarrassed.' If excuses are barriers, Dustin's life is the unanswerable rebuttal.

FOUR ACTIONS FOR ACCOUNTABILITY

(1) Resolve never to be the victim again. **(2)** Stop feeling sorry for yourself. **(3)** Be willing to take different actions. **(4)** Associate with accountables. Who you spend time with shapes the mindset you adopt.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Accountability is ownership, not consequences. It is a stance, not a punishment system.
2. You control only your thinking and your actions. Everything else you can only influence.
3. Self-pity produces nothing but more self-pity. Disappointment is okay; let it become a decision, not a habit.
4. If you want different results, do different things. Action changes outcomes AND attitude.
5. Avoid victim cultures. Surround yourself with people who own their lives and refuse to make excuses. The mindset is contagious in both directions.

CHAPTER 19

12 Week Commitments

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 19

Commitments are accountability projected into the future. The challenge is that we have stated intentions (above the iceberg's waterline) AND hidden intentions (below it) that often conflict. Successful commitment requires reconciling the two: surfacing the hidden costs you'd rather not look at, and deciding consciously whether the prize is worth the price.

THE ICEBERG OF INTENTIONS

Stated intention: 'I want to lose weight.' Hidden intentions: 'I like to eat,' 'I don't want to exercise in the cold,' 'I want comfort,' 'I've always been heavy.' If the hidden intentions outweigh the stated one, you don't change. Successful commitment makes the stated intention stronger — or reconciles the conflict honestly.

FAILURE vs. FOLIAR (JIM COLLINS)

Rock-climber Jim Collins distinguishes between *foliar* (you fall, but you never let go) and *failure* (you let go). To the outside observer, both look the same. The difference is internal: in foliar, you hold nothing in reserve, you give your full self. Commitments demand foliar, not failure. Don't give yourself a psychological out.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Use the four keys for every commitment: strong desire, keystone actions, count the costs, act on commitments not feelings.
2. Surface your hidden intentions. The conflict between stated and hidden goals is what kills most commitments.
3. Commitments to others build trust. Broken commitments destroy relationships. Treat your word as currency.
4. Don't over-commit. Most people would rather hear 'no' than receive a 'yes' you don't deliver on.
5. Commit to foliar, not failure. Don't give yourself a psychological out. The growth comes from going to your real limit, not your comfortable one.

CHAPTER 20

Your First 12 Weeks

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 20

Your first 12 weeks may be your most important. Casey Johnson's experience: he dabbled at first and saw little progress. After three months, he committed fully — hired a coach, scored honestly, attended a WAM, valued his time. By the end of the second 12-week cycle, he ranked #4 in the country at his experience level in his company's annual life sales promotion. His message: **don't dabble. Engage.**

THE THREE 4-WEEK PHASES

Weeks 1–4 — Install: Build the habit. Score every week. Plan every week. Attend a WAM. Don't worry about results yet — master the routine.

Weeks 5–8 — Sustain: The newness has worn off, the year-end is still distant. Productive tension peaks here. Push through. Address breakdowns directly.

Weeks 9■12 — Finish strong: Full year-end push energy, four times a year. Even if you won't hit the goal, finish strong. The 13th week is for reflection, regrouping, and recommitting.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. Don't dabble. Engage fully. Half-application produces half-results.
2. First 4 weeks: install the routine. Plan, score, WAM. Don't focus on outcomes yet.
3. Middle 4 weeks: this is where productive tension builds and people quit. Stay in. This is where the system pays off.
4. Last 4 weeks: finish strong. Whether you hit the goal or not, finish strong sets up the next 12 weeks.
5. Don't lie about your score. The system can't help you if you fake the data.

CHAPTER 21

Final Thoughts & the 13th Week

Section Reference: Part 2, Ch. 21

At the end of every 12-week year is a 13th week. It's a buffer for unfinished work, a window for honest reflection, and a launchpad into the next 12 weeks. The After Action Review — what worked, what didn't, what to change — is essential. Without reflection, you repeat the same patterns. With it, you compound learning across cycles.

THE TWO LIVES

The book opens and closes with the same idea: most of us have two lives, the one we live and the one we are capable of. Don't settle for less than what you're capable of. The 12 Week Year is a system for closing the gap between those two lives — not eventually, not someday, but in the next 12 weeks.

TAKEAWAYS & APPLICATION

1. The 13th week is a planning week, a recovery week, and a celebration week. Use all three.
2. Conduct an After Action Review at the end of every 12-week year. What worked? What didn't? What changes for next time?
3. The system is only useful if you apply it. Knowing about it produces nothing.
4. Don't wait for things to be just right. Start where you stand, with what you have, today.
5. You have everything you need to be great right now. The only question is whether you'll choose to be.

PART II

"GET ME THERE" ACTION GUIDE

A standalone playbook to install the 12 Week Year in your life and business — starting today.

"GET ME THERE" ACTION GUIDE

This guide reorganizes the 12 Week Year into four operational phases mapped to the book's own framework: **DESIGN** (vision, goals, plan), **EXECUTE** (weekly plan, time blocks, tactics), **SUSTAIN** (measurement, WAMs, productive tension), and **RELOAD** (the 13th week and the next cycle). Each phase has concrete actions you can begin now.

PHASE 1: DESIGN — Vision, 12-Week Goals, and Your Plan

Write Your Aspirational Vision

Imagine your life 5–15 years out. Cover all seven domains: spiritual, spouse/partner, family, community, physical, personal, business. Be bold. Make it big enough to be slightly uncomfortable. Small visions don't call on your best.

Compress to a 3-Year Vision

Based on the long-term vision, what does life look like 3 years from now? Be specific. The more concrete, the easier the 12-week goals become.

Set 1–3 12-Week Goals

Goals must be a realistic stretch. If you can hit them with your current approach, they're too small. If they feel impossible, factor back. Specific, measurable, time-bound, and owned. Less is more.

Write the 12-Week Plan

For each goal, identify the highest-priority weekly actions that will produce it. Each tactic starts with a verb, is a complete sentence, has a due week, and has an owner. Brainstorm wide; implement few.

Connect Vision to Daily Action

Print the vision. Review it daily. The vision is the why; the plan is the how. Without the emotional connection to the vision, the plan won't survive the Valley of Despair.

PHASE 2: EXECUTE — Weekly Plan, Time Blocks, Daily Action

Build Your Model Week

On paper, schedule strategic blocks (3 hours, 1x weekly), buffer blocks (30–60 minutes, 1–2x daily), a breakout block (3 hours, 1x weekly), and recurring critical activities. If it doesn't fit on paper, it won't fit in real life.

Create the Weekly Plan

Each Monday (or Friday afternoon), spend 15 minutes pulling the tactics from your 12-week plan that are due this week. This is your weekly plan. Print it. Carry it. Work from it daily.

Protect Strategic Blocks Fiercely

3 hours, no email, no calls, no visitors. Just one focused session per week on your highest-value work. Schedule it early in the week so you can reschedule if disrupted.

Batch Email and Admin in Buffer Blocks

Stop checking email all day. Concentrate it in buffer blocks. The rest of your day belongs to your strategic priorities.

Take the Breakout Block

3 hours away from work, scheduled, not optional. Burnout kills creativity. The block is investment, not indulgence.

Check the Weekly Plan Daily

5 minutes each morning. Check in once or twice through the day. Don't go home until that day's tactics are complete.

PHASE 3: SUSTAIN — Score, WAM, Productive Tension

Score Your Weekly Execution

Each week, calculate the percentage of planned tactics you completed. The target is 85%. Don't lie about the score — the system can't help you if the data is fake.

Track Lead and Lag Indicators

Lag = results (revenue, weight, conversions). Lead = activities (calls, workouts, prospect meetings). Track both. The lead numbers predict; the lag numbers report.

Form a WAM Group of 2–4 Peers

Meet weekly, 15–30 minutes. Each person reports: progress to date, weekly score, intentions for next week. Followed by group feedback and encouragement. Peer support multiplies success rate up to 7x.

Embrace Productive Tension

When you see your low score and feel uncomfortable, that's productive tension. Don't shut it off by quitting the system. Use it as fuel to act.

Diagnose Breakdowns Correctly

Bad results? Check execution score first. If you weren't executing, the plan isn't the problem. Most people change the plan when they should change their behavior.

Don't Quit After a Bad Week

Bad weeks happen. Don't bail. Score it, recommit, plan, attend the WAM. The bad week becomes fuel, not a verdict.

PHASE 4: RELOAD — The 13th Week and the Next Cycle

Run an After Action Review

End of week 12 or in week 13: what worked? What didn't? What will you do differently next cycle? Without reflection, you repeat the same patterns. With it, you compound.

Celebrate Progress, Not Just Outcomes

Whether or not you hit the 12-week goal, recognize the execution wins. Celebration fuels the next cycle. Skipping it bleeds motivation.

Take a Real Break

Three-day weekend, week-long vacation — something. Reflect, regroup, recharge. The system is designed for sustained execution, which requires recovery.

Reconnect With Your Vision

Has it changed? Is it still compelling? Does the next 12-week goal still serve it? Vision is a living tool, not a frozen document.

Set the Next 12-Week Goal

Use the AAR to inform the next cycle. Same goals refined? New goals altogether? More focus, fewer tactics? The next 12 weeks is a fresh year. Use it.

QUICK REFERENCE: ALL PRINCIPLES

1. Execution — not knowledge, talent, or strategy — is the single greatest market differentiator.
2. The annual plan is a barrier to performance. Treat every 12 weeks as a complete year.
3. Vision is the starting point of all high performance. Personal vision fuels business goals.
4. Plans must be action-based, not objective-based. 1–3 goals max. Tactics: specific, measurable, dated, owned.
5. The Weekly Plan is your most important tool. It's a 1/12 slice of the 12-week plan, not a to-do list.
6. Measurement is the anchor of reality. Track lead AND lag indicators. Hit 85% on your weekly execution score.
7. Performance Time uses three blocks: strategic (high-value work), buffer (admin), breakout (recharge).
8. Accountability is ownership, not consequences. You always have choice.
9. Interest is conditional. Commitment is unconditional. Use the four keys: desire, keystone actions, costs, action over feelings.
10. Greatness is chosen before results show it. The choice is available right now.
11. Life balance is intentional imbalance, not equal time across all areas.
12. The Emotional Cycle of Change is predictable. The Valley of Despair is where most people quit. Don't.
13. Don't go it alone. WAM groups multiply success rates up to 7x.
14. Productive tension is a signal, not a problem. Use it as fuel.
15. Don't dabble. Engage fully. Half-application produces half-results.
16. The 13th week is for reflection, recovery, and recommitment. Use all three.

"If we did the things we are capable of doing,
we would literally astound ourselves."
— Thomas Edison